Insuring Our Future

WHEN IT CAME TO LIFE AND CAREER decisions, Vibha Padalkar preferred to tread off the beaten path. She could have emulated her mother, a civil servant, or chosen a career in engineering as her father. What excited her more was the jet-setting corporate life of an uncle. Born and schooled in Chennai, she did her CA course in London as her father was posted there in the Indian High Commission. She landed a job in London when she was just 19. It was here that she formed what she calls a "world vision".

Back in India, she worked first with Colgate Palmolive, before moving on to WNS Global Services, a business process management firm. It was around the time when its ownership changed from British Airways to private equity firm Warburg Pincus. "It was as close to a start-up as one could get in those days," says Vibha. She led the team at WNS to get the firm listed on the New York Stock Exchange.

"I was looking for a sunrise sector as I realised that the energy I gained from creating something and being part of the growth story was very exciting," she says. She did not have to wait too long. HDFC Group's Deepak Parekh was on the WNS board, and that helped her to move on to HDFC Standard Life Insurance Company in 2008. Before becoming CEO in 2018, she was its executive director and chief financial officer. The hurdles in the insurance sector were many, not the least of which were government regulations in 2010 that cut margins. "I had to go back to my drawing board and think of ways we could be frugal," she recalls. When she joined, HDFC Life was in the fifth place among private players in the space, but after "reinventing" itself, moved into the top three.

ACCOMPLISHMENT
Drove HDFC Life's acquisition of Exide Life Insurance in 2021, one of the biggest deals in this space

Vibha Padalkar, *55*
MD & CEO, HDFC Life

As CEO, she drove HDFC Life's acquisition of Exide Life Insurance in 2021. The firm has opened an office in GIFT City in Gujarat, selling dollar-denominated products to NRIs. Its pension subsidiary has crossed Rs 60,000 crore in assets under management. Vibha acknowledges the support of her husband and her son through her career. Her son would never demand she skip her work, even for a day, she says. ■

–M.G. Arun

DO YOUR OWN THING

"It's okay if you want to be a career woman...but you must introspect about what you want, as women are continually apologetic or living someone else's life"

UNWIND TIME **Loves trips to wildlife sanctuaries, which she says is "an annual pilgrimage". Favourite wildlife destination is Bandhavgarh in MP**



MILIND SHELTE